

Reading into Writing – Demographics

How should governments react to the shift toward low fertility and population aging described by Sciuba as, “the most fundamental shift to take place in modern human history”.

Extract One:

Ezeh, A. C., Bongaarts, J., & Mberu, B. (2012). Global population trends and policy options. *The Lancet*, 380(9837), 142-148.

After more than a half century of unprecedented growth, the global population reached 7 billion individuals in 2011. This modern expansion of the human population started at the onset of the industrial revolution in the late 18th century with a decline in the death rate in Europe and the USA and Canada. In the 20th century, reductions in death rates in Africa, Asia, and Latin America followed, leading to a population explosion at the end of that century.

Nowadays, growth continues in most countries, but declines in birth rates are offsetting declines in death rates and population size is expected to reach 10·1 billion at the end of this century. If this projection holds, the world’s population will have grown by more than tenfold—from 0·8 to 10 billion—between 1800 and 2100. In this report, we summarise variations in growth and their consequences for different regions of the world and then present policy options for addressing undesirable population trends in developing and developed countries.

Policy options in countries with low fertility

Although much attention of policy makers and researchers has justifiably focused on high fertility in the developing countries of sub-Saharan Africa and southeast Asia, concerns about the adverse effects of below-replacement fertility in economically advanced countries are rising rapidly. Policy makers have, until recently, been reluctant to support pro-birth measures and action. Several factors explain this reluctance: a disinclination to interfere with personal decision making about family size, the apparent inconsistency of

advocating pro-birth policies at home while supporting efforts to reduce fertility in developing countries, the hope that fertility will soon increase again without intervention, and the high cost of intervention.

However, this reluctance has now largely disappeared as the cost of inaction becomes increasingly evident and efforts to reform pension policies and health-care systems have proven difficult and unpopular. Moreover, if fertility remains very low then reform alone will be inadequate to address the problems. Various measures have been implemented or are being considered, including birth bonuses, family support measures (e.g., subsidised childcare), reduced taxes for families with children, paid parental leave, and even a dating service in Singapore.

Such measures can be expected to raise fertility because on average in most developed countries, actual fertility is lower than desired family size and reductions in the cost of childbearing will make it easier for women to combine a career with the preferred level of childbearing. Reviews of the past effect of such measures conclude that they can indeed raise fertility, but the effect is modest. Country studies in the past 10 years in Japan, Italy, and Spain, among others, confirm this conclusion and show that pro-birth policy measures can have different effects in different institutional, cultural, or economic environments.

Another important policy option linked to addressing low fertility in economically advanced countries is immigration. However, some researchers estimate that hundreds of millions of immigrants will be needed to keep the ratio of working age people to dependants constant in the many countries with low fertility. Despite increasing approaches to limiting the migration of unskilled people, policies in high-income countries with low fertility are converging on the need to attract increasing numbers of highly skilled workers and this objective is being realised through regular immigration programmes in countries such as Canada, Australia, the USA, France, Germany, and the UK. The effect of this pattern of migration on development in the countries of origin of the immigrants is not clear and the traditional debates around so-called brain drain (and more recently on brain gain) are dominant themes in discussion of international migration and development.

Extract Two:

Bloom, D. E., Canning, D., & Lubet, A. (2015). Global population aging: Facts, challenges, solutions & perspectives. *Daedalus*, 144(2), 80-92.

Counteracting the potential negative consequences of population aging will involve some combination of behavioural and policy changes. These may include increased rates of savings during the working years; increased labour supply from women, older people, and immigrants; thoughtful policy programs; increased retirement ages; and other adjustments. The combination of interventions chosen will determine how costs are divided among current and future generations of older people. Countries can ensure a smoother transition to an older population by initiating policy and institutional reforms sooner.

The solutions mentioned above may not only ameliorate the potential economic burden of population aging, but may also enhance the well-being of older people, which is an independently valuable result. Increased longevity can also be of great benefit to society. Older people are repositories of work experience, knowledge, and culture. Regarding them as a resource is critical to cultivating a more effective work force and offsetting labour shortages. In a globalized world where knowledge and human capital provide an advantage, the experience of older workers is valuable. Positive perceptions of aging individuals, their overall integration with society, and mitigation of ageist beliefs will also benefit their quality of life. Indeed, subjective well-being—life satisfaction, feelings of happiness, and sense of purpose and meaning in life – has been shown to be closely related to physical health, a link that is particularly important at older ages and is associated with longer survival. Shifting the perspective away from an ageist view of burden and diminished value and toward a positive view of older people who offer experience, wisdom, and leadership will enhance their lives and lead to behaviours and policies with the power to resolve or offset the challenges presented by aging.

Adopting policies that allow for healthy living throughout life and into old age will encourage this more positive perspective to take hold. Population aging has vastly different potential for benefit or harm to societies depending on whether aging populations are independent and healthy or are disabled and in need of costly long-term care. As discussed above, it remains to be seen whether increased longevity will introduce improved quality of life and a higher proportion of healthy years. While disability traditionally does increase along with age, research in the United States has shown that in recent decades the incidence of disability at older ages is declining. Policy interventions can reinforce this growing trend: higher socioeconomic status and higher levels of education among older men and women across multiple countries correlates with reduced disability and chronic disease incidence. Higher education levels and improved health at older ages has led to such sayings as “seventy is the new sixty,” a sentiment reinforced by findings that the average self-reported health of a sixty-nine-year-old man in the United States in the 2000s was the same as that of a sixty-year-old-man in the 1970s. Although demographic change is daunting and has historically introduced significant obstacles to societal cohesion and economic growth, the bottom line is that demography is not destiny. Individuals, businesses, and governments have the option to adapt in the face of change, and many solutions are within reach. The sooner policy changes are considered and implemented, the sooner population aging can transform from a challenge into an opportunity.

Extract Three:

Jones, G. W. (2019). Ultra-low fertility in East Asia: Policy responses and challenges. *Asian Population Studies*, 15(2), 131-149.

There are only three ways to increase population more rapidly, or minimise its decline: lower mortality, raise fertility or increase net migration. East Asian countries like China, Korea and Japan already have some of the highest life expectancies in the world. This leaves us the other two levers – fertility rates and migration.

Given China’s massive population, it is unlikely that rates of net migration, either inward or outward, could ever be large enough to greatly affect population growth or decline. In

Japan and South Korea, though, if substantial migration were to become politically acceptable, it could make a real difference to the rates of population growth or decline. But the numbers would have to be substantial. In 2014, an official panel advised the Japanese government, to accept 200,000 permanent immigrants per year. The argument was that this could prevent population falling below 100 million. There were two major problems with the proposed policy. The first was that the Japanese public show strong resistance to the idea of accepting substantial numbers of immigrants. The second was that even 200,000 immigrants would not halt a population decline. (At the present time, Japan's population was contracting by 300,000 every year.) So far, the idea of a substantial immigration policy has neither the support from governments nor from the people (Draught, 2015).

Unless a substantial immigration policy is to be implemented soon, fertility policies have to be the core of approaches in addressing population decline. Such policies include support for childcare, increased parental leave, options to enhance work–life balance and payment of monthly child allowances. Many East Asian countries have begun to implement these measures, notably Singapore. However, the evidence suggests that policies to date have had little impact in raising fertility. Why is this the case? Largely because countering the forces making for ultra-low fertility requires the adjustments of entrenched cultural, institutional and familial arrangements that are not easy to achieve. While policies have certainly moved ahead in positive ways, workplace cultures have yet to follow suit; long days still being the norm for full-time workers. In addition, changes in gender roles continue to lag behind with women expected to do most of the childcare, and the pressures of educating children and finding housing in cities are the continuing realities faced by couples considering marriage and childbearing. As such, government policies face an uphill task in altering fertility intentions.

Ultimately, no one policy can deal with all the unresolved issues. A number of things are clearly needed. Firstly, governments in the region need to pressure employers to modify the work culture; combining work and family rearing is particularly difficult if there are very long working hours, if workers are expected to work at short notice outside normal working hours, if annual leave is short and there is no provision for family leave when a child is sick. Secondly, greater financial support for parents is needed. In discussions of

factors related to low fertility, the financial costs of children regularly come to the fore as a major deterrent and financial insecurity for both women and men clearly acts against decisions to have more children. Thirdly, a range of developments that would help women in dealing with the major issue of effectively combining family raising and career is required; the slow changes in the attitudes of men need to be accelerated, so that the burden of bearing and rearing children does not fall so heavily on mothers at the cost of their careers. Finally, in East Asian countries, there is enormous pressure on parents, especially mothers, to raise 'successful' children. The pressures this culture places on parents or potential parents, can hardly be exaggerated. This 'educational arms race' needs to be modified. Once these developments take place, there is a chance that the rational decision by many women to opt out of marriage and childbearing can be changed in ways that will lead to higher fertility.